

Starting and sustaining a conversation

NPTTEL

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*MOOC
Soft skills
development*

Overview

- Activities
- Silence
- Conversation and processes involved
- Masks
- Contexts
- Summary

Activity 1

- Two persons stand back to back and talk: emphasis on non-verbal communication
- Then they repeat the same looking at one another.
- Ask them for feedback about the difference
- Assign them some contexts first

Activity 2: active listening

- Ask two persons to converse – one speaks and the other acts as if he is not interested in listening
- Then repeat the same indicating that the other is interested in listening – what's the difference?
- What strategies of active or uninterested listening have been used? – ask the audience and ask them to identify some more.

Activity 3: Paraphrasing

- Ask two people to communicate a complex message. The first person speaks. The second person paraphrases. How much was communicated and how effectively?
- Try this back to back: this will lead to phone conversation. What special listening skills (ask for feedback, etc) are required. What speaking skills are required.

Silence

- The Buddha's silence
- The Story of the Arrow
- The Woman and Mustard seeds

Conversation

- A Personal Anecdote
 - Meeting someone after 8 years about his son.
- Learning points
 - ...

Processes involved

- Listening
 - Language
 - Style
 - tone
- Speaking
 - Language
 - Style
 - tone

- Body Language
 - Distance
 - Territory
 - Eye contact
 - Facial expression
 - Gestures
 - Postures

- Context
 - Environment
 - Semantic context
 - Emotional context
- Culture and convention
- Power relation
 - Superior-subordinate established
 - Fight for superiority

Masks

- As father to son/mother to daughter/son or daughter to parents
- As friend to friend
- As senior to junior
- As boss to subordinate
- As subordinate to boss

Do we speak the same way ?

- Role play
 - Senior to Junior
 - Student to teacher
 - Friend to friend

Assessment and learning points

- Telephone

- Voice, tone, grain against the medium (phone) and silence
- Warmth and feeling conveyed against style
- Intent and meaning against emotion, feelings and style

After the phone call

- Talk with someone and then meet the person for the first time
- How do we respond?
- Learning points
- *Check our activity on the Discussion Forum*

The human side

- We get hurt easily
- We get offended easily
- We feel neglected easily
- Human communication is not easy
- How much time do we spend in communicating, and how much on taking care of the above points, especially in the first few meetings?

Listening	Speaking
How do you listen? Listening is saying you are interested.	Is someone listening? Is s/he getting the message?
Conveying emotions and feedback as you listen (dynamism)	Changing the style and tone based on change in the listener's attitude
Allowing space, allowing time	Allowing space, allowing time
Agreeing and disagreeing	Respecting the other's view. Not leading questions?

Contexts

- Informal
- Formal
- Pleasant
- Unpleasant
- Visual
- Auditory

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Summary

- Conversation is a complex process involving the entire human organism – speech and non-verbal communication
- Conversation in different contexts has different implications
- It is important to take into consideration the human side of conversation – has great implications in the context of soft skills